

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1986-10-27

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,
2 your very thought-provoking letter of 24 june 1986 has been the subject
3 us to send you the following reply.
4 The crucial task before you in relation to your two little daughters would
5 seem to be to foster their confidence in and love for god, their acceptance
6 of his will and their assurance of the validity of the bahá'í principle of the
7 equality of men and women. in working towards this there are certain facts
8 of history and principle in the f aith that you need to accept and reconcile.
9 you raise two basic issues, that all the manifestations of god known to
10 us have been men, and that they have appeared in the east.
11 'Abdu'l-b ahá himself in a talk given in malden, massachusetts, confirms
12 that "The east has ever been the dawning point of the Sun of reality. All
13 the prophets of god have appeared there. The religions of god have been
14 promulgated, the teachings of god have been spread, and the law of god
15 founded in the east. The orient has always been the center of lights." (The
16 Promulgation of Universal Peace, p. 289) indeed, one can see that the proph-
17 ets of god named in the Scriptures have appeared, not just in the east, but
18 in a very limited area of the east, stretching from the levant and egypt
19 across iran as far as india. we have no authenticated records of chinese or
japanese prophets. however, to complement this we must remember that
20 the founders of the great religions are but one of the kinds of prophet,
21 and we should study the following q ur'ánic statements:
And every nation had an apostle; so when their apostle came, the
22 matter was decided between them with justice and they shall not be dealt with
unjustly.

(Surah 10, verse 7)

And certainly we raised in every nation an apostle saying: Serve god

23 and shun the devil. . . .

(Surah 16, verse 6)7 .1

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9 11And on the day when we will raise up a witness out of every nation,

then shall no permission be given to those who disbelieve, nor shall

10 they be made to solicit favor.

(Surah 16, verse 8)

11 . . . And there is not a people but a warner has gone among them.

(Surah 5, verse 2)

12 There are prophets mentioned in the qur'án, such as húd and ʔálíʔ,
13 about whom the bible is silent. idrís, whom the qur'án states was a proph-
14 et, is identified with hermes by bahá'u'lláh, who states "i n every tongue
15 he hath a special name."7-1 it is clear that he must have lived in very ancient
16 times. bahá'u'lláh made no mention of buddha, and if it had not been for
17 'Abdu'l-b ahá's statement we would not have been in a position to state defi-
18 nitely that buddha had been a manifestation of god. There are a myriad
19 traditions in the legends of peoples that point back to some sort of divine
20 revelation but, as the beloved guardian's secretary pointed out on his behalf
21 in a letter written to an individual believer on 13 march 1950, ". . . we can-
22 not possibly add names of people we (or anyone else) think might be lesser
23 prophets to those found in the qur'án, the bible and our own Scriptures.
24 for only these can we consider authentic books." we must just accept that
25 there are undoubtedly many prophetic figures of whom all authentic record has been
lost. As to the future, the research department knows of no Text

26 which states explicitly in which country manifestations of god will appear.
27 The reason for the appearance of a manifestation of god in a given place
28 is not to honor a particular people or nation. Shoghi effendi indicates a
29 quite different reason in The Advent of Divine Justice and, more concisely, in
30 a letter to an individual written on his behalf on 23 January 1944:

The ever-recurring miracle in the establishment of every religion is

that such poor instruments accomplish the work of god. it is to dem-

31 onstrate the fact that god is the power that overcomes every obstacle,

and that revelations are divine in origin, that leads him to always

32 7-1. Tb, p. 148.7 .4c

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8 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

9 12choose the worst people among whom to manifest his messenger and

the most obscure and helpless of the population—relatively speak-

ing—to establish the foundations of his faith. The bahá'í dispensa-

10 tion is no exception to this rule, as you yourself have observed.

11 beyond these points is the fact that god, the Almighty creator, does not

12 have to justify his choice of a race or nationality from which to raise up a

13 manifestation. As all sacred scriptures tell us, he does as he wills and shall

14 not be asked of his doing, and we bow in humility before him. besides,

15 as you must know, conceptions of race, nation, oriental, occidental, and

16 the like reflect earthly limitations and are not qualifications attached to the

17 reality of the soul in the limitless realms of god.

18 regarding your desire to assist your daughters to overcome their percep-

19 tions of the unequal status of women, you are perhaps not aware of the compilation
on women recently released to National Spiritual Assemblies.

20 7-2

21 Through the divine insights and instructions provided in this compilation,
 22 you can inspire your daughters with knowledge of the glorious station to
which women are called in the Age of bahá'u'lláh, and imbue them with
 23 assurance in the promises of the blessed beauty, so that through constant
 24 endeavor they may become as brilliant stars radiating a spirit of freedom
 25 from the stultifying notions of the past. on the particular question of the
relationship between womanhood and prophethood, it is hoped that the
 26 following comments will be of help.
 27 even though there have been outstanding women such as Sarah, ásíyih,
the virgin mary, fá-imih, óáhirih and the greatest holy leaf in every
 28 dispensation, it is an incontrovertible fact that all manifestations of god
 29 known to us have been men. moreover, it is a clear provision in bahá'í
administration that the guardians were to be men and that membership
 30 point to a differentiation in function that is unalterable, or whether it was merely a
 characteristic of a period which will change when mankind attains
 31 its maturity is a matter that will, no doubt, become clear in the future. The
 32 important point for bahá'ís to remember is that, in face of the categorical
 33 7-2. for the compilation, see cc 2:355–406 or <http://reference.bahai.org/en/t/c/>

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 9 1 pronouncements in bahá'í Scripture establishing the equality of men and
 10 women, even these facts are no evidence at all of the superiority of the male
 11 over the female sex. 'Abdu'l-bahá has explained that equality does not mean
 12 identity of function. he has also stated that the few areas in which men and

women are not equal are “negligible.”7-3

13 we must also remember that sex is a characteristic of this world, not of
 14 the spiritual world. when the guardian was asked about “soul mates” and
 15 the problem that could arise in the next world if one were to remarry in this
 16 life, his secretary replied on his behalf, on 4 december 1954:

17 There is no teaching in the bahá'í faith that "soul mates" exist.

18 what is meant is that marriage should lead to a profound friendship of spirit, which
will endure in the next world, where there is no sex, and no giving and taking in marriage;
just the way we should establish with our parents, our children, our brothers and sisters and
friends a

19 deep spiritual bond which will be everlasting, and not merely physical

20 bonds of human relationship.

21 The house of justice hopes that these remarks will help to ease some of
22 your perplexity and will assist you and your dear wife to raise your daughters
23 as devoted and knowledgeable bahá'ís, confident of the validity of the prin-
24 ciples promulgated by bahá'u'lláh. Surely as they meet problems and ques-
25 tions and face them fearlessly, their understanding of the cause of god will
26 deepen and this will increase their ability to deal with the difficulties of life.

we are asked to assure you of the prayers of the house of justice in

27 the holy Shrines that . . . and . . . may be the recipients of god's constant
28 benediction and that their parents may be divinely assisted to protect and train them.
29 with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the secretariat

30 7-3. cc 2:371.7 .10

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8 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

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New Stage in External Affairs of the Faith

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]